

conducted a romance with a widow, Rebecca Schröter. His concerts, for which he wrote six new symphonies, were a triumph. Known today as his “London” Symphonies, they are among his best-loved works. Haydn went again to England, in 1794–1795, composing six more symphonies for the occasion. The London concerts were a success financially as well as musically. He was now a wealthy man.

The accession of a new Esterházy prince, Nikolaus II, in 1794 led to a partial resumption of Haydn’s duties. He produced a series of Masses and in 1797 wrote a patriotic anthem for the Austrian Empire, then engaged in desperate warfare against the armies of the French Revolution. Partly through the influence of the young Beethoven, Haydn explored new musical territory. Composed in 1797–1798, his final set of string quartets, Op. 76, and his last piano trios exceed any of his previous chamber works in intensity and expressive range.

Two oratorios, *The Creation* (1798) and *The Seasons* (1801), formed the climax of his creative life. Inspired by Handel’s oratorios that Haydn had seen in London, they set libretti by Gottfried van Swieten (based respectively on the Book of Genesis and the poetry of James Thomson). *The Creation* in particular inspired fervent enthusiasm in its audiences. It was given more than 80 performances in Haydn’s lifetime, both in Vienna and abroad.

Aging and ill, Haydn retired in 1802. His last appearance was at a performance of *The Creation* given in his honor in 1808. He died the following year in Vienna. His final days were not peaceful, coinciding with a major defeat of his beloved Austria